

SESSION SIX: THE SECOND SEAL

The Qilvayas Symphony

An adventure for 4–6 characters of 5th level — the dead letters read, the Church's hand forced, and the first descent

OVERVIEW

Everything converges. The Empress's two ciphered documents — the party's rubbing and Shen's final filing — go under Archivist Vell's eye and give up a translation that changes the shape of the campaign. The Office of Omens, its patience spent, executes its Writ of Examination against Vaelindra at the blue-shuttered house, and the party's choices decide her fate and their standing with the Church for years of play. Her hand forced, Vaelindra finally gives the party the middle tier of the truth she has carried for fifty years. And then, following a dead woman's bearings, the party opens a mason's door in the base of Zhuvedus's own monument and descends beneath the Old Forum — through the catacombs, past the First Seal, through the unquiet dead — to end the session standing before the Second Seal, in cold that has waited two thousand years to be felt again, listening to a sound they know from a dream.

Designed for a five-hour core. Pacing budget: reading the dead letters, and the hole in the Fourth Book (55 minutes); Shen, and what the translation is worth (25 minutes); the Writ at Ninth Lane, run in its four phases (75 minutes); Vaelindra's hand, forced (40 minutes); the descent through the seven keyed areas (70 minutes); the Second Seal (15 minutes, unhurried — it is the cliffhanger and the arc's final image). Optional content adds up to two further hours. The party reaches 6th level when the session ends at the Seal.

On the descent. Seventy minutes for seven areas is five minutes less than the previous budget allowed for the same journey, and it buys a great deal more, because the areas give the DM somewhere to put the time rather than a single long corridor to narrate. D2 and D4 are the two that must not be hurried; D1, D6, and D7 are each a single image. If the table is behind, D2's four hundred years of the capital's dead can be one paragraph instead of five minutes, and nothing structural is lost.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Nyreeza's two documents, combined, contain: a surveyed route into the Old Forum catacombs beginning at a mason's access door in the monument plinth; wardline notations for what she called the First Seal (an imperial-era barrier she breached, neatly, alone, three years ago); a depth, a bearing, and the phrase already known from the Cold Door — "colder past the second seal" — and a final passage in her personal cipher that Vell will read aloud once and never agree to repeat: "If I do not return: the wound predates the Wall. The Tablets were written over it. He must not follow me. Tell him the garden, not the grave." The first sentence confirms the campaign's buried truth from the Empress's own hand. The second — that the Golden Tablets, the empire's sacred founding law, were composed over the wound — is a revelation whose full meaning should be allowed to detonate

slowly across many sessions. The third is a mother's protection order. The fourth is a private code between Nyreeza and her son that no one at the table can yet unlock — it keys to the sealed dispatch case in the Empress's study, and it is the campaign's promise that this thread runs through the throne itself.

Meanwhile, Odell moves. His writ — stronger or weaker depending on the Session Five interview — authorizes the Examination of Vaelindra of the Still Waters on grounds of unsanctioned interpretation of divine contact. Examination is not execution: it is custody, questioning, and "resolution into a file," which for a woman of her age and knowledge might mean comfortable house arrest in a Sanctum cell for the rest of her life, every ledger she owns confiscated and read. Odell believes he is protecting people. The writ is legal. That is the problem the party must actually solve — the law is not on the side of the truth, which is this campaign's oldest joke and the least funny one.

SCENE 1: READING THE DEAD LETTERS

The Overdue Volume is a teahouse two lanes off Scholar's Row where the academy's retired and disgraced drink leaf-water strong enough to trot a horse, and where the proprietor enforces silence with a look that has ended marriages. Vell holds a corner table the way a fortress holds a pass. He examines both documents for eleven minutes by the clock without speaking, and the party gets to watch a man read his own past: he archived nine years of this hand. When he finally speaks, it is to the tabletop. "I will read it once. I will not repeat it. And then, colleagues, you are going to tell me everything, and for the first time in forty years I am going to leave my ledgers unbalanced and help you."

Give the translation scene its full hour: the mechanics of the cipher (Vell narrating Nyreeza's shorthand habits with terrible tenderness — she crossed her sevens; she abbreviated 'forever'; her hand shakes only in the final passage), the route, the seals, and the last four sentences landing one at a time. Let the players sit with "The Tablets were written over it" without any NPC explaining it. Vell's contribution beyond translation: he can confirm from archive records that the monument plinth's mason-door exists (a maintenance access, sealed by custom, not lock — masons' guild superstition holds that work on the Founder's monument is "paid in bad years"), and he identifies the final line as private code with the certainty of a man who sorted the Empress's personal correspondence: "That sentence has an addressee, and the addressee wears a crown. What you do with that fact will define you. Choose slowly."

SCENE 2: WHAT THE TRANSLATION IS WORTH

If the Shen alliance stands, she must be told something — the documents were pooled on terms. Thirty minutes of genuine strategic table-talk: does the party share the full translation (Shen, hearing “He must not follow me,” goes silent for a long moment and then says, very quietly, “Then she was protecting him. Three years I wondered. Thank you” — and the question of whether Shen now tells the Emperor becomes hers, and live), a partial version (she knows within days that it is partial; the alliance survives exactly one such discount), or nothing yet (breach of terms; she does not threaten, she simply notes it, which is worse). If there is no alliance, this scene becomes the party alone with the knowledge, and the DM should let the silence of that — nobody in the world knows what they know — do its work. Either way, the scene ends with the same interruption: a breathless runner from Coppergate. Gray robes at Ninth Lane. Many of them.

SCENE 3: THE WRIT AT NINTH LANE

They have blocked both ends of the lane with the quiet efficiency of people who practice: eight examiners in Office gray, a censor-captain in half-armor beneath his robes, and Prelate Odell himself, standing before the blue shutters with a document in both hands like a man presenting a gift. The copyist's shop below is shuttered — its proprietor nowhere in sight, which tells its own story. A small crowd of Coppergate neighbors has gathered at the barriers, and they are not neutral: this is their district, and the old woman upstairs has read the weather and the omens for their grandmothers. Above, one blue shutter stands open. She is watching. She does not look surprised. She looks like a woman confirming a fifty-year-old appointment.

This is the session's crucible, seventy-five minutes, and it must be run so that every path is real. The writ is legal; force is the worst answer available; and the scene is built so that the party's accumulated choices — the Odell interview, the Highcourt standing, the Shen alliance, their Seal-house training — are the arsenal. Four principal resolutions, any of which can succeed or fail forward:

A — The Law: The writ's ground is “unsanctioned interpretation of divine contact.” A Seal-trained challenge, argued on the spot or before a magistrate within the hour: Vaelindra has interpreted nothing — she takes testimony and cites historical pattern; she claims no contact and counsels no claimants (if the party avoided registering in Session Five, this is where that pays: DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion) with advantage; a registered party argues at disadvantage and Odell smiles through every word). Success does not kill the writ — it suspends it pending review, buying months and humiliating the Office publicly, in front of the district. Odell accepts defeat like a professional and begins building the next writ that afternoon.

B — The Politics: A Highcourt marker — Kessin's favor (if earned and kept), or Shen's intervention (the Bureau can

“discover” that the Examination of a witness in an open imperial inquiry is obstruction) — quashes the writ from above. Cost: the marker is spent, the benefactor now owns a piece of Vaelindra's freedom, and the Church logs precisely who reached over its head. Corvane herself takes note of the party's name for the first time — which cuts both ways forever.

C — The Vanishing: Extraction — the party's own plan over the rooftops, or Shen's people, or the Coppergate crowd “accidentally” breaking the cordon. Vaelindra escapes into a life in hiding (Shen's safehouse, the party's office, or — the branch with teeth — an offer of sanctuary that arrives, within days, from the See of Orlath, which delights in sheltering the capital Church's victims). She is safe, and the party has made her a fugitive and themselves accessories; the Office's next writ names them.

D — The Surrender: Vaelindra's own preference, if the party has no better card and asks her honestly: she goes with them, upright, in front of her district — and the party works her release from outside (any of A or B pursued afterward, harder). She has survived the Church for fifty years; she can survive its hospitality for a season. “But come for me,” she says, at the door, without drama, “because the ledgers go with me, and I have not finished teaching you to read.”

Violence deserves its own warning label rather than a lettered branch: the examiners fight nonlethally and the party can absolutely win the lane — and lose the campaign's civic ground. Assaulting a lawful Church examination in public makes the party fugitives of the Sanctum, locks the capital's institutions against them for an act, and hands Odell the only thing his case lacked: proof that Vaelindra's circle is dangerous. If the table goes this way, let it — consequences are content — but make the cost legible before the first sword clears leather: Vaelindra herself, from the window, calling down “Children. Not like this. I have not spent fifty years being careful so that you could spend me in an afternoon.”

SCENE 4: HER HAND, FORCED

Whichever branch resolved the lane, this scene follows within a day — in her apartment, a safehouse, or the visiting room of a Sanctum cell (Odell permits visitors; recorded, naturally; she and the party may enjoy speaking entirely in weather metaphors). Vaelindra has decided: the Office's move ended the luxury of her silence, and the party has earned — or events have forced — the middle tier of fifty years of knowledge. She gives them, in her physician's cadence, with the ledger (or its memory) open before her:

The vision that ended her career, fifty years ago, entire for the first time: not the burning city — that came to others — but the founding itself, seen from below: “I saw that the founding was a burial. I saw the first Emperor stand over something that had trusted him, in a place that became the Old Forum, and I saw the law itself laid down upon it like a stone upon a grave. I reported it faithfully. Within a month I was a file. That is how I know your Prelate's office is very good at its work: I was trained in its methods, and I trained others.”

What Nyreeza sought, and what she and Vaelindra said at that last meeting: the Empress had found the same shape from the other direction — records, requisitions, dead seals — and came not for interpretation but for confirmation. “She

asked me one question: 'Is it still there?' And I told her the truth, which is that it was never anywhere else. She thanked me. She was the only person in fifty years who believed me the first time. And then she went down alone, because she was an Empress and the mother of an Emperor, and she would not risk anyone she ruled. Her hand shakes in that cipher because she already knew she was not coming back up."

The warning, and the withholding: "What is under the Forum is a wound, and wounds this old have names, and I will not say them — not from mystery, but because names have weight down there, and you have not yet earned the strength to carry them. Go and stand where she stood. Read what she read. Come back alive, and I will give you the names, and you will wish I hadn't. And children — the Emperor. His mother's last sentence was for him, and it was 'do not follow.' Honor it a while longer. The day you bring the throne into this, you cannot bring it back out." (**DM note:** she is deliberately withholding Threnvos, Zhuvedus's fall, and the oath-mechanism — the full account remains the mid-campaign payoff, canon-per-sourcebook, once the party returns from the threshold.)

SCENE 5: THE DESCENT

At night the Old Forum belongs to the mad, the destitute, and the stone. Zhuvedus's monument stands at its heart the way it has for twenty centuries — a robed figure, features worn to suggestion by two thousand years of hands touching the hem for luck — and at the base of the plinth, exactly where a dead woman's bearings say, a mason's access panel opens on hinges that someone oiled three years ago. The stair beneath is pre-imperial: black stone, fitted without mortar, treads worn hollow in the middle by feet that predate the empire whose founder stands above. The cold begins on the ninth step. The medallion begins on the tenth.

Run the descent in three movements across seventy-five minutes:

The Bone Galleries: Imperial-era catacombs — centuries of Aenodira's dead in wall niches, oldest at the bottom, and Nyreeza's survey cipher blazing the route at every fork like a trail of quiet fireflies (finding each mark: DC 12 Investigation, automatic for the rubbing's carrier). Skill texture, not combat: a collapsed gallery to bypass (Athletics/engineering), a flooded stretch (the Ostrun leaks), and the growing wrongness — every niche within thirty feet of the true route holds dead that lie perfectly, unnaturally undisturbed, as though nothing that scavenges will come near.

The First Seal: A full imperial wardline across the passage — wolf-standard sigils, Old Imperial invocations, professional work of the founding era — with a neat, surgical breach at its base: Nyreeza's work, three years old, annotated in her cipher with the date and a single word: "alone." The wards are dead where she cut them and dying elsewhere; a detect-magic reading shows the whole line fading like an old scar, which raises the question no one need answer aloud: the First Seal was maintained, once. By whom, and when did they stop? Passing the breach, every character feels the temperature drop as a pressure rather than a chill; the medallion's carrier makes a DC 12 Constitution save or takes a level of exhaustion's cold cousin — no mechanical penalty, just the DM's note that their breath now fogs when no one else's does.

The Unquiet: Past the First Seal, the interment niches are older than the empire — and the nearest dead do not rest. The Hollow Dead rise: 4 (5 for five characters, 6 for six) plus the Sepulcher Chill, a colder and older thing wearing the gallery's dark like a garment. They do not moan; they whisper — and a character who listens (or fails a save) catches the words, which are the vision's imagery in the mouths of the pre-imperial dead: the storm, the wrong fire, the shape behind the sky. They have been dreaming it down here longer than the empire has existed. Radiant damage and daylight-grade light are the tactical keys; the Chill dissolves rather than dies, flowing not away from the party but deeper — toward where they are already going.

SCALING THE UNQUIET

Baseline (4 characters, 5th level): 4 Hollow Dead + the Sepulcher Chill in a two-wave rhythm (dead first, Chill from the dark on round 2) — an adjusted-hard encounter with the environment as the real enemy (niched terrain, 10-foot visibility past torchlight). Five characters: +1 Hollow Dead. Six: +2, and the Chill opens the fight already manifested. The party should end this fight resourced-down and rattled; the session's final scene is meant to be walked into tired.

SCENE 6: THE SECOND SEAL

The gallery ends, and the architecture changes — not built, but hewn: a single vault of the black mortarless stone, older than every bone behind you, and at its far side, the door. You know it before the light reaches it, because your body knows it: the Cold Door beneath the academy was a postern — this is the gate. Twenty feet of black stone furred white with frost in air that has never known winter, worked across its whole face with carvings your academy educations have no alphabet for — and, small and human at its foot, the last of Nyreeza's marks: her cipher, and beside it, scratched deeper and less steadily, in plain Imperial anyone can read — the word she wrote when the cipher stopped being enough: FORGIVE. The medallion is a coal of cold against its carrier's chest. And through twenty feet of stone that has held for two thousand years, faint and vast and patient, comes a sound. You know it. You have known it since a night at the Gilded Ford. On the far side of the Second Seal, something that has always been here is breathing in its sleep — and as you stand there, in the deepest cold of the oldest dark, it turns over.

End the session there — on the sound, the word, and the cold. Do not open the Seal; do not let anything come through; do not resolve. If a player attempts to force or magic the door, let every attempt fail with total, geological indifference and one consequence: the sound pauses. Listening. Then resumes. That is enough. Milestone: the party reaches 6th level on the walk back up into the lamplight of a city that has no idea what it is standing on. The next arc — what the Seal requires, what Vaelindra's names cost, and what happened to the woman who wrote FORGIVE — begins with Session Seven.

THE DESCENT, KEYED

Scene 5 takes the party under the Old Forum for the first time, and the route matters, because they will use it again in Sessions Seven and Eight and because a route the players have mapped is a route they own. Seven areas from the Forum floor to the Second Seal.

The shape of it. Down, and then east. The public stair on the Forum's east side serves the upper Bone Galleries and stops at a consolidation hoarding that has been there since before living memory. Behind the hoarding the galleries continue down four more levels, and at the bottom of the fourth the masonry changes and the Undercourt begins. The funerary traffic never comes below the second level, which is why this route is available and why nobody has walked it in a century.

D1. The East Stair. Public, lit, swept, and entirely ordinary. Vigil-keepers pass here at all hours and will nod. This is the last well-lit place for two sessions.

D2. The Upper Galleries. Two levels of interments, oldest at the bottom, arranged in wall-niches by century. Dry, cold, and profoundly peaceful. Nothing here is hostile. A party that hurries through misses the point: this is where every Zhuvedian in the capital ends up, and the party is about to walk past four hundred years of them.

D3. The Consolidation Hoarding. Timber, painted, official, and eighty years old. A notice board beside it carries a work order that was never completed. The hoarding is not locked. It is simply a hoarding, and going past it is a decision rather than a break-in — which is exactly the kind of threshold this campaign likes.

D4. The Closed Galleries. Two more levels, unswept, undisturbed, and — the first genuinely wrong thing — noticeably colder than the levels above, in a place where depth should mean warmth. A DC 13 Wisdom (Survival) or any character who has held Dren's medallion knows that is backwards.

D5. The Change of Stone. Imperial brick gives way to black stone fitted without mortar, the same as the Cold Door and the same as the Founder's Wall a mile above. There is no doorway; the two masonries simply meet, and one of them was there first.

D6. The Approach. A corridor that is not a corridor: too wide, too tall, and proportioned for a procession. The Undercourt proper. Sound behaves oddly here and the party will notice before the DM says anything.

D7. The Second Seal. Where the session ends. See the scene text; nothing in this keying replaces it.

THE WRIT AT NINTH LANE (SET PIECE, IN PHASES)

Scene 3 is the session's set piece and it is a siege of paperwork, not of walls. Run it in four phases with a decision at each transition. The Office of Omens does not break down doors; it arrives with a document, and the horror of the scene is that everything Censor-Captain Odo does is lawful.

Phase One — The Knock (10 minutes). Odo arrives with four and knocks. He presents a Writ of Examination naming Vaelindra, and he waits to be admitted. The decision: does the party open the door? He will wait a long time. He has waited before. Refusing is legal, costs nothing immediately, and changes the whole scene into a siege — which is what he would prefer, because a siege is a fact he can write down.

Phase Two — The Reading (15 minutes). Admitted or not, the Writ is read aloud in full, at the door or through it. It is long, it is precise, and it is correct. The decision: does anyone challenge it on its own terms? A DC 15 Intelligence (History) or any character with a legal background finds the defect — the Writ names Vaelindra and does not name her premises, which under Book Four means it authorizes examination of a person and not a search of a house. Odo will concede the point instantly and courteously, because he is not a liar, and will then simply ask her to come with him, which is what the Writ actually permits.

Phase Three — The Choice (20 minutes). Vaelindra's hand is forced. The decision belongs to her and the party can influence it, and the module must let them fail: she can go, which ends the immediate danger and begins a much worse one; or she can refuse, which makes her a fugitive within the hour. What the party says here matters more than any check. Ask for a stated argument, not a roll.

Phase Four — The Departure (20 minutes). Whatever was chosen, Odo leaves, and how he leaves is the phase. If violence has occurred, he is a wounded officer with witnesses and the party are now a filed matter. If it has not, he leaves a copy of the Writ, thanks them, and — this is the line to deliver carefully — asks each of them their name, and writes them down, and does not react to any of them.

DM Only: Odo believes he is protecting the empire from a hundred unlicensed prophets and he is, in the main, correct. Play him warm. He should be the most reasonable person in the room and the party should not be able to hate him cleanly, because the campaign's whole argument is that institutions do terrible things through people who are behaving well. If the table wants a villain here, refuse to supply one.

THE FOURTH BOOK CONCORDANCE (PUZZLE)

Scene 1 is the party reading what they recovered, and as written it is a translation. Make it a reconstruction: the letters give a set of register citations, and the citations point at a hole. The puzzle is noticing the shape of an absence.

Six citations, all to the Fourth Book, of Seals and Record. Five of them resolve: ordinary deposit entries, dry as chalk, dated across one season twelve years ago. The sixth resolves to an entry that says a document was DEPOSITED and does not say by whom, in a register whose whole purpose is to say by whom. And when you check the five that worked, all five have the same Hand, and it is not the Hand of the clerk who was working that season.

What it means. Somebody deposited six items under a borrowed clerk's hand and left one of them unattributed. That is not a forgery; it is worse and quieter. It is somebody

with legitimate access using it in a way the register cannot describe.

Solution one — the concordance. With Mosse’s secondhand concordance, DC 13 Intelligence (Investigation) resolves all six citations in an hour. The sixth is the finding and it announces itself.

Solution two — Vell. Take it to the Archivist. He will resolve it in four minutes, go very quiet, and then be extremely careful about what he says next — because the Hand in question is one he knows, and it has no business being on those entries, and he has spent twelve years not asking himself why.

Solution three — the register itself. Go to the Archive and pull Book Four for that season. Slow, public, and it works, and it also means the party’s names are now on a request slip in the archive’s own record, which is a real cost and should be stated after they do it, not before.

Solution four — the negative. A party who never resolves the citations at all can still get there by asking who was clerking that season and finding that the answer is one person who was demonstrably somewhere else. This is the hardest route and the most satisfying, and a DM should be ready for it because clever tables find it.

TRAPS AND HAZARDS ON THE DESCENT

The Hoarding (D3). No mechanics. Stated here because a DM will want to put a lock on it and should not. The whole point is that nothing prevents them. Going past a notice that says do not is the session’s real threshold and it should cost nothing but nerve.

The Cold (D4 onward). Environmental. Marked thin-written ground, worsening with depth. Long rests taken below D4 restore half the usual Hit Dice. Ritual casting takes twice as long and may simply fail. Divination returns grief rather than answers — and a DM should have one specific, personal, useless piece of grief ready for each player character, because that is far more frightening than a failed spell.

The Niche Fall (D2 and D4). Mechanical hazard. Eight hundred years of interments in wall-niches, and the mortar in the closed galleries has gone. A creature that climbs, braces against, or fights beside a niche wall: DC 12 Dexterity save or a section gives — 2d6 bludgeoning, and the party is now standing in somebody. There is no monster in this. The horror is entirely in the apology.

ENCOUNTERS IN THE GALLERIES

Roll a d8 on the descent, once per level below the hoarding. Most of these are not fights, and that is the level’s whole atmosphere.

d8	What Happens
1	A vigil-keeper on the upper galleries, working late,

	who will talk about the consolidation hoarding and what she has heard behind it.
2	A niche with a lamp burning in it. Fresh oil. Four levels below where anyone goes.
3	Rats, and then the absence of rats, which is worse and which happens one level lower.
4	A Thin-Written Echo (see the Gazetteer’s bestiary) repeating one gesture from a funeral eight hundred years ago.
5	A collapsed section of gallery revealing a level below that is on no plan the Church holds.
6	Cold that arrives as a front, moving, and passes over the party in about four seconds, and does not come back.
7	A Vigil-Wight (see the Gazetteer’s bestiary) in the closed galleries, unwatched for a century. It can be laid to rest by keeping its Vigil, and the party has somewhere else to be, and that is the encounter.
8	Their own light, reflected off something a long way ahead that should not be reflective.

HANDOUT — SESSION SIX

THE WRIT OF EXAMINATION

BY THE OFFICE OF OMENS, under the Third Book, of the Sanction and the Charter, and by the writ of the Synod of the Grey: TO VAEINDRA, called of the Still Waters, of the parish of the Ninth Lane, greeting. You are required to present yourself for examination touching claims of divine contact received and interpreted without Sanction. This writ is served upon your person. You may bring one companion. You are not accused. — F. ODO, Censor-Captain, for the Prelate of the Office.

Note for the DM: read You are not accused in exactly the tone of a man who means it, because he does. And note what the writ does not say: it names her person and not her house, which is the defect in Phase Two, and it is right there on the paper for any player who reads the handout carefully instead of listening to it.

OPTIONAL CONTENT (BEYOND THE FIVE-HOUR CORE)

The Tarnovar Envoy (~45 minutes): A rare Tarnovari trade delegation is in the capital — stone-touching, oath-shy, unsettling the Exchange — and their evening at the Patched Standard includes a performance by their singer, Ilinca Verath: the Lament of Vosthren the Betrayed, in Tarnovari, translated in murmurs by a homesick clerk at the next table. The party hears, without any mechanical prompt, a two-thousand-year-old ballad describe a sworn covenant, a beloved traitor, and a grief buried ‘beneath the victor’s house.’ No one else in the room reacts. Design function: the campaign’s deepest secret, performed openly in a tavern, audible only to the people who have stood at the door it

describes. If a party member speaks with Ilinca afterward, she is warm, proud of the old songs, and entirely ignorant of their truth — which is its own kind of chilling. Seeds the Tarnovar arc; record interest in the Branch Ledger.

Race-Day (~40 minutes): A Golds-and-Greys race-day on the Long Course — the capital at its loudest and most alive: faction chants, terrible meat skewers, a photo-finish dispute adjudicated by a magistrate with a speaking-trumpet, and the party's first ground-level read of the civic machine that will someday produce the Grey-Gold Rising. Pure texture plus one planted observation for attentive players: both factions' chants are loyalty songs to the city — and neither mentions the Emperor at all.

The Plums Come Back (~30 minutes): If the party took the Farrowgate client in Session Five: a follow-up scene — the mother returns with the daughter's final unsent letter, recovered from a teamster, describing the Countess's 'night garden' and a rule about singing after dark. If they declined: the scene arrives anyway, colder — the mother does not come back, and Brakka reports she has taken passage south alone, to knock on Greywell's gate herself. If a party member healed her cough in Session Five, it is back — not as a rebuke, and not as a mystery: she went home to the same rooms and the same water. Either branch sharpens the future module and keeps the jar of plums on the shelf doing its quiet work.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

Record outcomes in the Branch Ledger. Session Six is the arc's great branching point — handle its consequences with the weight they deserve.

The Writ (A/B/C/D/violence): A (law) — Vaelindra free, Office humiliated locally, Odell rebuilding; Church standing recoverable. B (politics) — free at the price of a spent marker and Corvane's attention; the benefactor holds a piece of her. C (vanishing) — free and fugitive; party implicated; the Orlath sanctuary offer opens a door to the See that no other branch opens this early. D (surrender) — she is in Sanctum custody, composed, recorded, and expecting rescue-by-law; her ledgers are in Office hands, which will matter. Violence — fugitive branch for the party; capital institutions lock; Odell vindicated. Every branch keeps Vaelindra alive and the campaign's spine intact; what changes is the cost of reaching her and who owns the favors.

The translation and Shen: Full disclosure deepens the alliance and hands Shen the 'He must not follow' question — her decision about the Emperor becomes a live NPC arc the DM controls. Partial disclosure survives once. Silence breaks the alliance quietly. No alliance at all: the party owns the truth alone, and the campaign's loneliness dial turns up a notch.

The throne (major gate): If the party defies both Nyreeza's last sentence and Vaelindra's counsel and brings any of this to Qilvayas or his court now, do not block it — but treat it as the campaign's single largest divergence: the early-throne branch collapses the slow-burn structure and must be improvised with care. Recommended handling: access friction (Kessin's desk, remember) buys the DM one session of delay to prepare; and 'the garden, not the grave' gives Qilvayas a reason to receive the message in private and act slowly. Flag this branch prominently in the Ledger if it opens.

The Seal, forced: Attempts to open the Second Seal now fail, full stop — but a party that persists loudly (sustained magical assault, demolition) earns a consequence: the Unquiet do not trouble them on the way out, because everything down there is listening to the door instead. Note it in the Ledger as 'the Seal has heard them.'

The envoy (optional): If any character engaged Ilinca or the delegation, Tarnovar's thread warms: the envoy will remember the southerners who honored the old songs, and the future Tarnovar arc opens with a friendly face instead of a cold border.

STAT BLOCKS

Hollow Dead

Medium undead, neutral evil

Armor Class: 13 (hardened grave-wrappings)

Hit Points: 39 (6d8 + 12)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	5 (-3)	10 (+0)	6 (-2)

Damage Resistances: necrotic; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Condition Immunities: charmed, exhaustion, frightened, poisoned

Damage Vulnerabilities: radiant

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

Languages: understands the whisper it repeats

Challenge: 1 (200 XP)

The Whisper. The Hollow Dead constantly murmurs fragments of the shared vision in a pre-imperial tongue. A creature that starts its turn within 10 feet and can hear must succeed on a DC 12 Wisdom saving throw or hear one intelligible phrase in its own language (the storm, the wrong-colored fire, the shape behind the sky) and have disadvantage on its next attack roll. A creature that has experienced the vision automatically understands every word, and knows it.

Sunlight Sensitivity. In daylight-grade light, the Hollow Dead has disadvantage on attack rolls and Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on sight.

ACTIONS

Grave-Cold Grasp. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (2d4 + 2) bludgeoning damage plus 3 (1d6) cold damage.

Sepulcher Chill

Large undead (residue-touched), chaotic evil

Armor Class: 13

Hit Points: 68 (8d10 + 24)

Speed: 0 ft., fly 40 ft. (hover)

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
6 (-2)	16 (+3)	16 (+3)	7 (-2)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)

Damage Resistances: acid, cold, lightning, thunder; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Immunities: necrotic, poison

Condition Immunities: charmed, exhaustion, frightened, grappled, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone, restrained

Damage Vulnerabilities: radiant

Senses: darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 11

Languages: —

Challenge: 3 (700 XP)

Incorporeal Movement. The Chill can move through other creatures and objects as if difficult terrain, taking 5 (1d10) force damage if it ends its turn inside an object.

Unnatural Cold. A creature that starts its turn within 5 feet of the Chill takes 3 (1d6) cold damage. Nonmagical flames within 30 feet gutter to half light.

Dissolution Deeper. Reduced below one-quarter of its hit points or struck twice by radiant damage, the Chill shrieks soundlessly and pours away through the floor seams — always, unmistakably, in the direction the party is heading.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The Chill makes two touch attacks.

Sepulcher Touch. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 10 (2d6 + 3) cold damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or its speed is reduced by 10 feet until the end of its next turn as the cold takes the knees first.

Censor-Captain Ferrin Odo

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral

Armor Class: 16 (half plate under gray robes)

Hit Points: 52 (8d8 + 16)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	13 (+1)

Skills: Athletics +4, Insight +4, Religion +3

Saving Throws: Con +4, Wis +4

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Common, Old Imperial

Challenge: 3 (700 XP)

Letter of the Writ. Odo announces his legal authority at the start of any confrontation and repeats it once per round as a free action. He and examiners under his command fight nonlethally without exception; a creature reduced to 0 hit points by them is stable and in custody.

Discipline of the Office. Examiners within 30 feet of Odo have advantage on saving throws against being frightened.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Odo makes two weighted-staff attacks.

Weighted Staff. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d8 + 2) bludgeoning damage (nonlethal), and the target must succeed on a DC 13 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

Invocation of Stillness (Recharge 5–6). Odo intones a Church binding. Each creature of his choice within 30 feet that can hear him must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or be unable to take reactions and suffer half speed until the end of its next turn.

Office Examiners at the Writ: use the Office Examiner stat block from Session Five (eight present; they act on Odo's orders and stand down instantly on any lawful resolution).

NPC NOTES

Prelate Sarvin Odell: See Session Five. At the writ he is the same man at higher stakes: correct, unhurried, and privately braced to lose — he has read the party's file and rates them. If beaten by law or politics he extends professional respect; if beaten by violence he extends a warrant.

Censor-Captain Ferrin Odo: Career Church soldier; took this posting because custody work 'keeps men honest.' Follows lawful outcomes to the letter, including ones that thwart him. Thread: Odo is winnable — a party that resolves the lane without blood earns his quiet regard, and a Church soldier's quiet regard is a strange key that will open a strange door someday.

Ilinca Verath (optional): Tarnovari singer, keeper of the old lament cycle, joyous and homesick and completely unaware of what she carries. Thread: the future Tarnovar arc's friendly face, if befriended.

LOOT AND FOUND

REWARDS — SESSION SIX — THE SECOND SEAL

Find	Value / Effect
Pre-imperial grave goods (the Bone Galleries)	Silver torcs and burial honors, 120 gp scrap value — and a live moral tripwire: Church law vests grave goods in the Matron; selling them is a crime, and (DM note) carrying them out of the catacombs makes the bearer's dreams cold for seven nights. The loot table is also a test. That is the setting

First Seal ward-fragment	Wardstone Shard (homebrew, below)
Nyreeza's survey chalk	Mundane. A half-used stick of surveyor's chalk, imperial issue, three years old. Heartbreaking. Free

REWARDS AND ADVANCEMENT

Coin: little — this session pays in truth. Items and intangibles: the full translation of the Empress's last words; the mapped, marked route to the Second Seal (the campaign's new fixed landmark); Vaelindra's middle-tier account and her promise of the names; the Writ's outcome with all its owed and owing favors; and the word FORGIVE, which the party will carry longer than any treasure. XP for tables using it: roughly 1,700–2,300 across the descent and the lane (full value for lawful resolutions). Milestone: 6th level at session's end, at the Seal. The first thirty hours of The Qilvayas Symphony are complete.

~

FORGIVE